

HOLY LAND, HISTORY OF



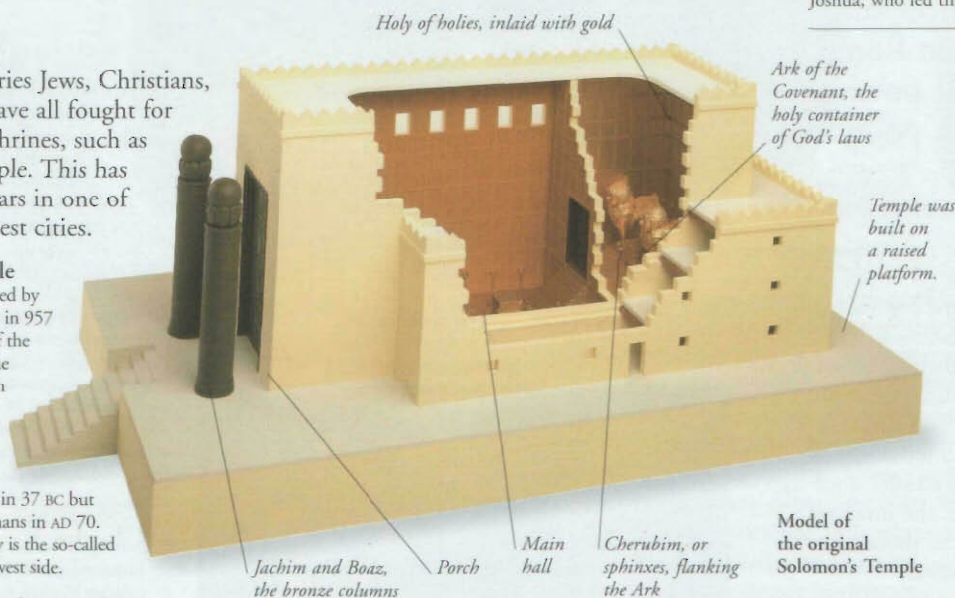
OVER THE CENTURIES, THIS VARIED region of mountains, deserts, and marshes has had shifting borders, various conquerors, and many names, including Canaan, Zion, Israel, Judah, and Palestine. The area is holy to three world religions: Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. Jews believe it is the Promised Land God gave them, and that Abraham, father of the Jews, settled there in about 1900 BC. The land is holy for Christians because Jesus Christ lived there; and for Muslims, Jerusalem is sacred as the site of many of Muhammad's activities. The Bible records mainly Jewish history in this region.

Jerusalem

Over the centuries Jews, Christians, and Muslims have all fought for access to holy shrines, such as Solomon's Temple. This has caused many wars in one of the world's holiest cities.

Solomon's Temple

This temple, completed by Phoenician craftsmen in 957 BC, housed the Ark of the Covenant, and was the first permanent Jewish religious centre. In 587 BC, the Babylonians destroyed the first temple. It was rebuilt in 37 BC but destroyed by the Romans in AD 70. All that remains today is the so-called Wailing Wall on the west side.



Dome of the Rock

This massive rock is sacred to Muslims because Muhammad is said to have risen to heaven from this spot. It is sacred to Jews because Abraham is said to have prepared his son Isaac for sacrifice here.

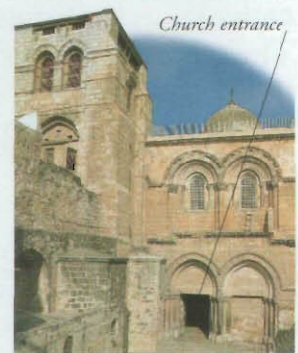


The Holy Land

This crossroads between Europe, Africa, and Asia has been conquered by Babylonians, Persians, Greeks, Romans, Arabs, Byzantines, Ottomans, and British in turn. Today it includes Israel, and parts of Jordan and Syria.

Jericho

Excavations show that the walled city of Jericho may be the oldest settlement in the world. According to the Bible, it was destroyed many times in its history – once by Joshua, who led the Israelites after the death of Moses.



Holy Sepulchre Church

In the 12th century, Crusaders rebuilt a Christian church on Mount Calvary, Jerusalem, where Jesus Christ was crucified. The church contains Greek Orthodox, Roman Catholic, and Armenian chapels. In a grotto underneath is the empty tomb of Jesus.

Philistines

The Philistines were part of a group of warriors also known as the Sea Peoples. In about 1100 BC, the Philistines threatened the Israelites, who had settled the southern coast of Palestine (in modern Israel). The Israelites lived subject to the Philistines for 200 years until the Israelite King David (r.1013–973 BC) managed to subdue them.



David and Goliath

Goliath, a huge Philistine champion, challenged the Israelites to present a man for single combat. No one dared respond until David, a young shepherd, volunteered. Against all the odds, he knocked Goliath out with one slingshot, and cut off his head. David went on to become Israel's greatest king, and made Jerusalem a great political and religious centre.

Timeline

c.8000 BC Evidence of human settlement, Jericho.

c.1900 BC The patriarch Abraham settles in Canaan.

c.1200s BC The Exodus: Moses leads the Israelites out of slavery in Egypt.



Holy Sepulchre Church

1033–1013 BC Reign of Saul, first king of Israel.

1013–933 BC Reigns of David and Solomon.

587 BC Babylonians destroy first Jewish temple, Jerusalem.

AD 33 Romans crucify Jesus Christ in Jerusalem.

AD 70 Romans destroy the second Jewish temple at Jerusalem.

636 Muslim rule begins.

1096–1291 European Crusaders fight to control the territory.

1948 Declaration of the state of Israel.

King Solomon

The son of King David and his wife Bathsheba, Solomon (r.973–930 BC) built the first temple at Jerusalem, and a number of cities. He was famous in ancient Israel for making profitable foreign alliances, and, during his reign, Israel reached its greatest extent of territory. Myths present Solomon as very wise, but he was actually a rather harsh and despotic ruler.



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